



Beyond Growth? Political Economy Perspectives

Living in the Anthropocene

28 September 2026, Laura Horn

WHAT IF GROWTH ISN'T THE ANSWER?

THURSDAY 1 OCTOBER

TIMOTHÉE PARRIQUE | SAMTALE MED HAKON
MOSBECH.

LIVING IN THE ANTHROPOCENE

Whatever you study, you study it in the Anthropocene!

Join us in this open, interdisciplinary seminar series with 10 sessions

7/9

Introduction

What is the Anthropocene, and what do we make of it?

14/9

Listen to the (climate) science!

Of Boundaries and Tipping Points

21/9

The Biodiversity Crisis

Earth System Science and Planetary Boundaries

12/10

Climate psychology

From value-action gap to ecological co-development

28/9

Beyond Growth?

Capitalism and the Limits of the Green Transition

5/10

Climate Politics and the Geopolitics of Transition

19/10

Life-making

in the Anthropocene

26/10

Communication

in the Anthropocene

2/11

Beyond the Tragedy

The Commons Game

9/11

End of course workshop

Learning and teaching in the Anthropocene

When
On Mondays
14:00 - 16:00

Where
Auditorium 46.1

All students are welcome
No registration necessary
Snacks and drinks included!

Follow for more



RUC

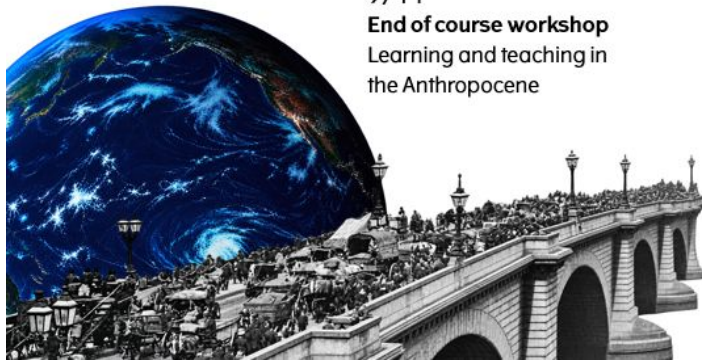
Where are we in the course?

→ Remember our (boiling hot) red thread

Focus: What is the problem/challenge, according to this perspective/discipline(s)? What is left out?

Agency: Who caused this, who can do something about this, what is stopping them, what would it take?

Ways of knowing: How do we know? Which concepts work for whom? Who counts, which knowledge is trusted? Whose voices are heard? How do we learn? What would change our minds?



Discuss with your neighbour

The [Exxon Valdez oil spill](#), Alaska, 24 March 1989 //
Deepwater Horizon disaster, Louisiana coast, 20 April 2010

Marilyn Waring, feminist economist, 1995:

*Economists would say the disasters were
good for the economy ([watch the documentary here](#))*



1. What does she mean here, in what sense was the spill "good for the economy"?
2. What does GDP count here, and what does it leave out?
3. If a disaster can raise GDP, what does that say about using growth as a policy objective in the Anthropocene?



Sustainability and growth

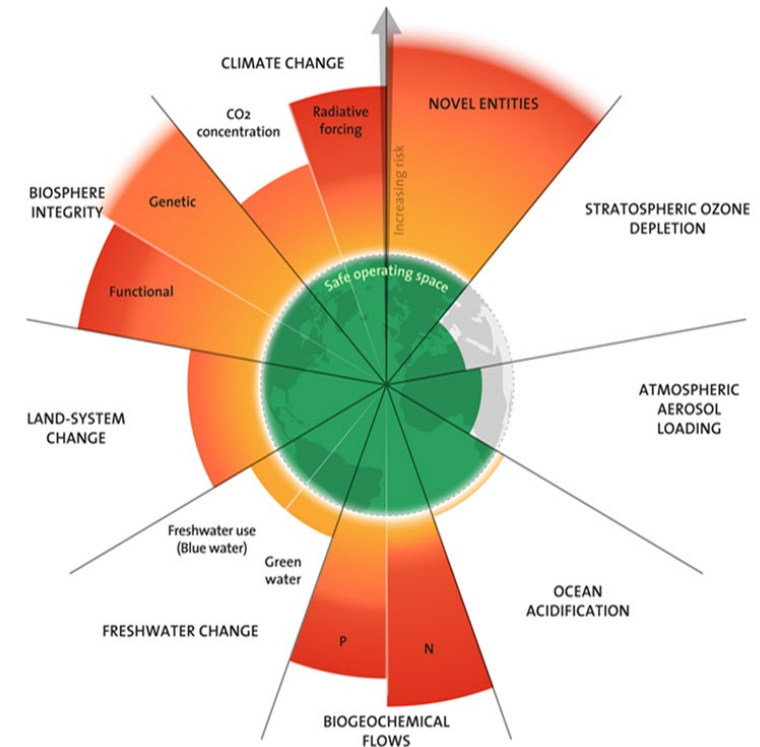
Brundtland Report 'Our common future' 1987

- **Sustainable development** [...] meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.

→ Can environmental sustainability be balanced with economic growth?

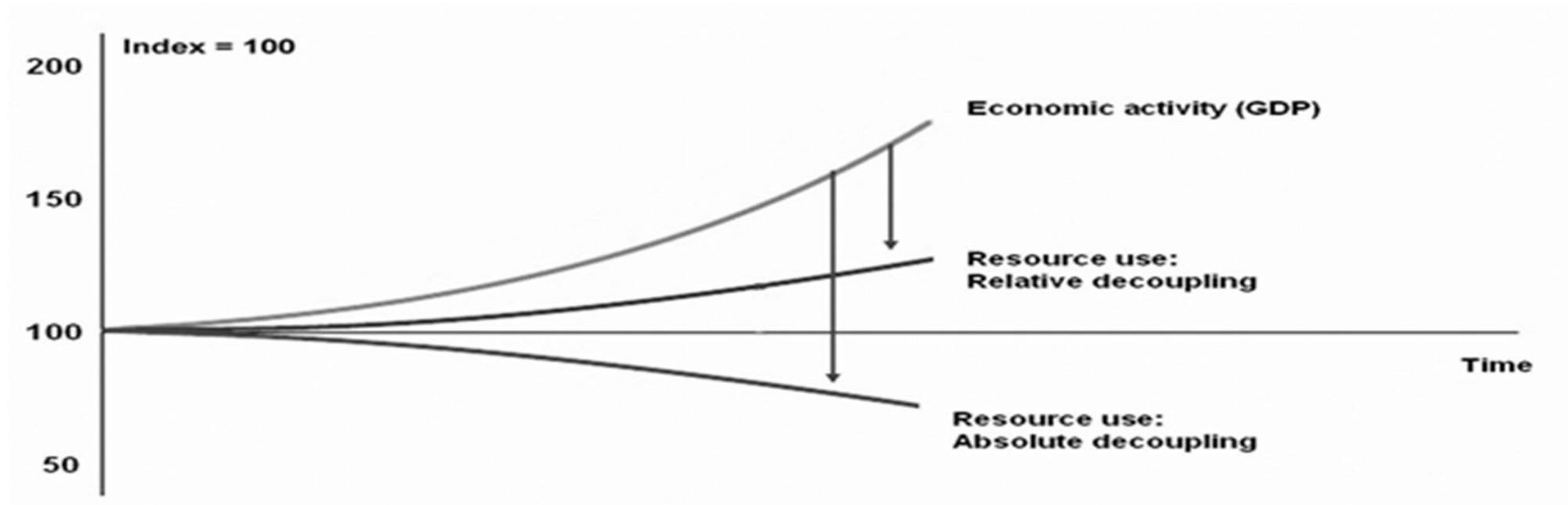
→ Can natural capital be substituted by manufactured/knowledge capital?

→ And whose limits/boundaries are we focusing on anyway?



Anthropocene
or
Capitalocene?
(Malm, Moore)

Decoupling – absolute and relative



→ Jevons paradox (rebound effect): technological process facilitates more efficient resource use; (possibly lowers costs), increased demand, increased resource use

(small) group discussion (10mins)



Energy consumption per AI query has declined massively, but much more energy-intensive use cases are becoming increasingly popular

Measured per individual task, the energy efficiency of AI is improving at a rate unprecedented in energy history. Software and hardware advances have resulted in the energy use per AI task dropping by at least an order of magnitude annually in recent years. Simple text queries now typically consume less electricity than running a television over the same period of time. If all conventional internet searches were performed with simple AI text queries, it would consume less than 4 terawatt-hours (TWh) of electricity annually, equivalent to less than 1% of total data centre consumption today.

However, new energy-intensive AI applications are increasingly being launched and used, such as those for video generation, reasoning and agentic tasks. These kinds of tasks can consume hundreds or thousands of times more energy per query than simple text generation. The energy demand of AI is therefore the result of three rapidly evolving and uncertain trends: improvements in efficiency, surging uptake, and changing model capabilities, which can unlock new and, in many instances, far more energy-intensive use cases. To improve the robustness of the outlook for AI's energy demand, close monitoring, frequent updates and cooperation with the tech sector, including more systematic energy consumption disclosures, will remain important.

The global electricity demand of data centres – the critical infrastructure for training and running AI models – grew by 17% in 2025, in line with IEA projections. Electricity consumption from AI-focused data centres grew even faster, surging 50% in 2025. While there are no comprehensive statistics on the frequency and depth of AI usage around the world, major model providers reported a threefold increase in active users and a fivefold increase in revenue over the past year, highlighting the rapid growth of demand.

1. What does Nadella (2025) mean?
2. What does the IEA (2026) report say? (link as URL in picture)
3. How can both of those be true at once?
4. (bonus question – why is Nadella happy about this?)



Break

The in/famous Ehrlich equation:

$$I = P \times A \times T$$

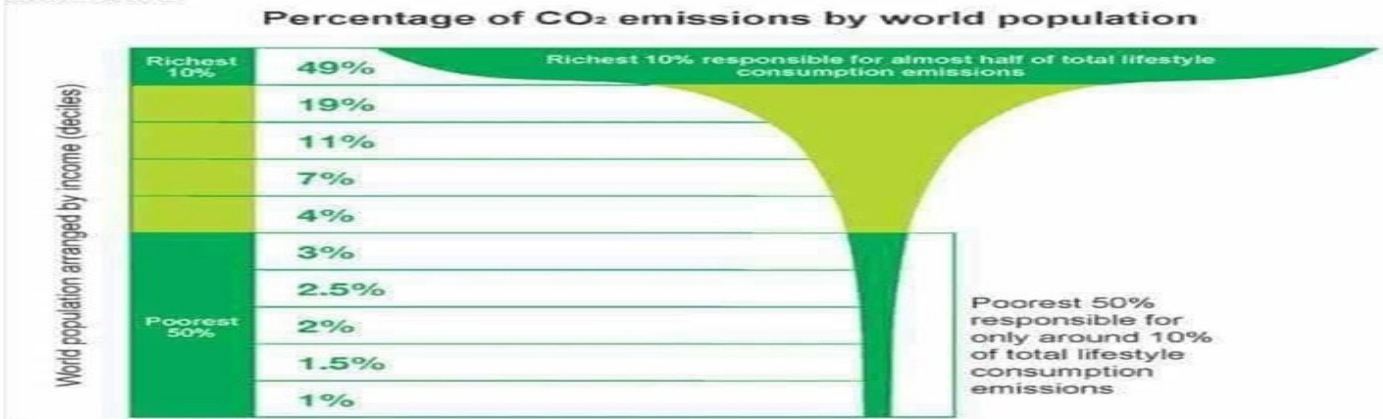
I = impact of human activity; P= population size; A= affluence level; T= technology factor (see Jackson 2009: 77/78)



Sofie Pelsmakers
@SofiePelsmakers

I'm an environmental journalist, but I never write about overpopulation. Here's why. buff.ly/2ycdWiY

Figure 1: Global income deciles and associated lifestyle consumption emissions



10/10/17, 9:52 AM



CNN
@CNN

Harvard and Yale scientists are proposing that we tackle climate change by dimming the sun.

It sounds crazy, but according to their research, it could actually cut the rate of global warming in half:

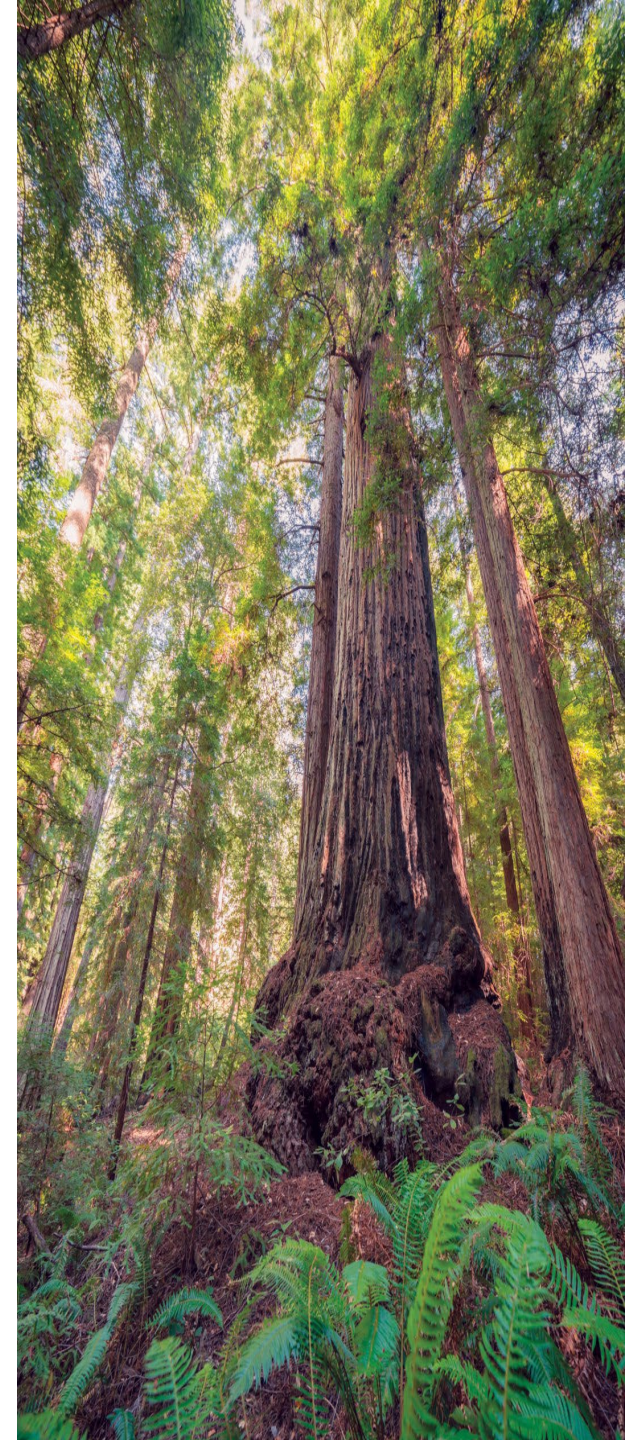
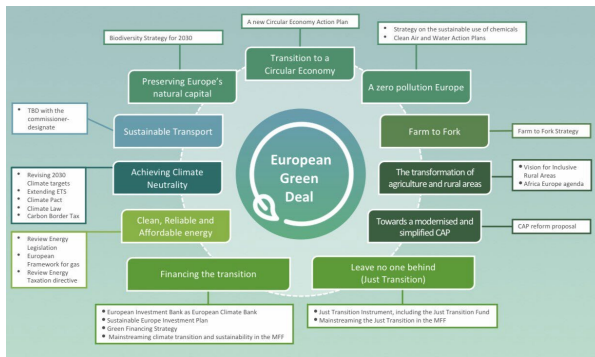


Brandy Jensen
@BrandyLJensen

lol we will fight the sun before we take on capitalism

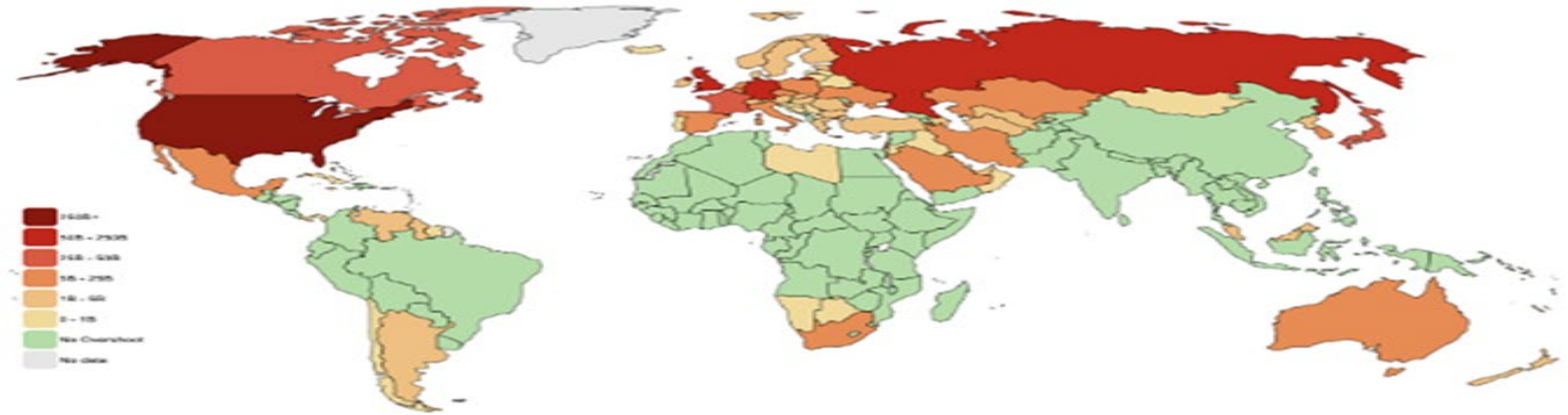
Capitalist pathways out of the crisis?

- Definitions and discussions of Green Growth
 - Economic sustainability, social sustainability, social justice
- ‘Absolute decoupling is not feasible on a global scale in the context of continued economic growth’ (Hickel/Kallis 2019:6)
- Ecological modernisation programmes, e.g. European Green Deal
- Which alternatives are being discussed?

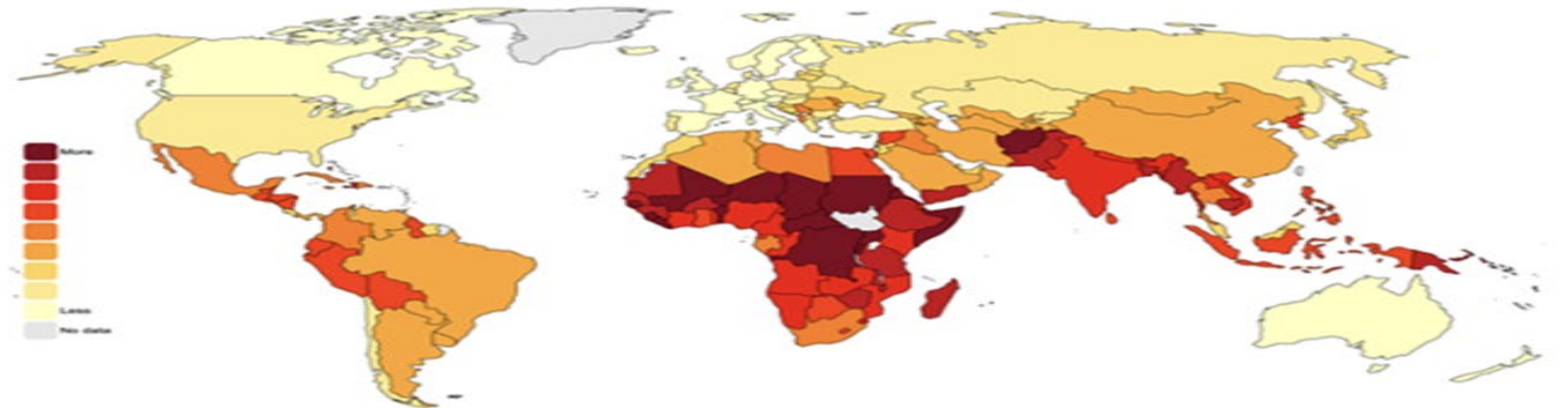


Growth and emissions in historical perspective

**Overshoot emissions
(Lancet Planetary Health)**



**Multi-dimensional climate
vulnerability
(ND-GAIN)**



From bananas to the Plantationocene

John's session (21/9): the clonal Cavendish banana

The backstory – the Plantationocene (Tsing, Haraway, Davis)

- built for growth: identical plants, cheap labour, long-distance markets
- Land dispossession under colonialism, forced labour, monocultures
- Political violence: Ciénaga massacre (Colombia, 1928), the Guatemala coup (1954); corporate power

But also – resistance, community-based organizing, alternative economic perspectives!



Next week 5/10 – Climate Politics

